

Παῦλος ὁ Σιλεντιάριος

Paul the Silentiary on the Description of Hagia Sophia

eul_aid: vfo

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)

Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)

Domain: Ποίησις [Poetry](#)

Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Paul the Silentiary was a Greek poet of the mid-6th century CE, active during the reign of the Byzantine emperor Justinian I. His epithet indicates he held the court position of silentiarios, responsible for maintaining order in the imperial palace. A contemporary of the historian Agathias, his sophisticated verse and high office suggest he was a well-educated member of the Constantinopolitan elite.

His two major works are both ekphraseis commissioned for the rededication of Hagia Sophia in 563 CE. The first is the **Ekphrasis of Hagia Sophia**, a 1,029-line hexameter poem describing the rebuilt church, and the second is the shorter **Ekphrasis of the Ambo**. Additionally, approximately eighty of his epigrams, primarily on erotic and convivial themes, are preserved in the Greek Anthology.

Paul is a significant figure in Late Antique literature, demonstrating the continuation of classical Greek poetic forms within a Christian Byzantine context. His ekphraseis are invaluable historical documents, providing a detailed contemporary description of Hagia Sophia's architecture and furnishings. His epigrams offer insight into the social and literary culture of the Justinianic court.

Works (2)

- [Περὶ τῆς Ἀγίας Σοφίας](#) · [Description of Hagia Sophia](#) · 66 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ Ἀμβωνος](#) · [Description of the Ambo](#) · 21 passages